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Christine Jensen

Christine Jensen is Assistant Professor of Saxophone and Contemporary Media at the prestigious Eastman School of Music. She is an active performer and composer, and regularly collaborates with her sister, Ingrid Jensen.

Christine was interviewed via Zoom on March 4, 2024 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm at Hamilton College and I'm pleased to be speaking with Christine Jensen who is at Eastman. I want to congratulate you on your career thus far.

CJ: Thank you.

MR: It's an interesting read and listen. Now if I'm correct that your job description at Eastman is Assistant Professor of Jazz Studies and Contemporary Media. Is that right?

CJ: Yes.

MR: So this is maybe an odd question but why do you think the powers that be at Eastman hired you? Because I'm guessing that there were probably quite a few applicants.

CJ: I heard there was a lot of applicants and I am replacing someone who is irreplaceable in the name of Bill Dobbins, who has left a legacy in so many ways. Why did they hire me? I can never get into that too much. I do feel this music and the movement of it is in for a big change especially within the institution walls of the young business of teaching jazz at the higher level, which only started fifty years ago or so. And there was a lot of tenure involved and there still is, but that generation is now starting to retire so I think we're going to see a lot more inclusion — best way I can put it — with where the music is going and where the education of the music is going.

MR: It's become a large business as well. I remember, I was at SUNY Fredonia and I graduated in '72 and we had a fine jazz band but there were no classes, there were no jazz professors, there was a struggle to get rehearsal rooms for jazz etcetera, and think of where it's at now.

CJ: We still have a ways to go though. I'm deep in thought of all of what you're talking about partly because I'm teaching a master's pedagogy in jazz course which we discuss a lot of these things and jazz in the institution has blossomed out of the classical institution, therefore they've held the reins and had all the rules and had all the space. And they have let us come into their space a little bit. And it hasn't been the other way around ever. So what you're describing is what I feel still.

MR: I've wondered, in talking with quite a few musicians and trying to remember who — I guess it was Ran Blake who said something about the Supremacy of the Ear. It might

have been his phrase, but it made me think about how can you justify at an institution like you're in, one famous around the world, if you wanted to spend a lot of time teaching young jazz musicians to use their ear, can you justify that in a curriculum?

CJ: Absolutely. Jazz is an aural tradition first I think. I don't think it was written down in the beginning, much like classical was probably not. Until the word "classical" was put on it was probably not written down. The refinement of our tools has pushed us into this western music corner of what to define as what to be taught. And in theoretical terms that's a heavy discussion, but in basic terms to me this music, which is jazz, is an aural tradition much — whether it's Duke Ellington or Louis Armstrong or the Delta blues guitar players or the country meets city blues that birthed this scene basically, it wasn't written down necessarily. Ellington eventually wrote things down but a lot of stuff was done by ear, and when we look at popular music a lot of that is done by ear as well. And it's also about really defining one's — or expressing — one's own individual voice at a very high level. So all those things together make me think wow, wouldn't it be great if we just had a school of aural learning.

MR: Can you spell aural for me?

CJ: A-U-R-A-L.

MR: I have a bug about that because —

CJ: Oh, O-R-A-L?

MR: Yes. You see people writing sort of what you're saying but they say O-R-A-L and I go, "no, no, no." I mean you're speaking but —

CJ: No I have students that are trying to describe this to me because they don't understand where they're coming from even, and they're at a very high level and they're trying to put this into words and every time I go, "All you're talking about is aural learning and that is what jazz is." If you can't do it by ear there's going to be a problem pretty fast in expressing yourself with this music.

MR: Do you think the access that they have now to just about everything in all the different media is a positive or negative to them learning the music and specifically learning to use their ear?

CJ: I want to say positive. There's some negative because it's not far off — I mean what a crazy thing — I now get to say I'm from a generation where when I was learning there was no cell phones, there was no internet connection, there was no media. All we had were records and tapes and cassettes and 50% slowdown playback. And hopefully the resources landed in front of us from someone that was able to share, I don't know, the right way to sift through a library or a record store or something, for us to get the information in front of us, right? And even before me, my generation, all they had were records. And before that generation all they had was piano player rolls probably. You

know what I mean? All of it is a learning tool that is very strong. And it's kind of about sifting through it. Now they just have way more to sift through, just like media. We have way more to sift through. And it's easy to get things covered up. It's funny because a student of mine played me, he did a listening test on me and I completely failed it. It was Lester Young, Buddy Rich and guess the piano player. You'd never guess the piano player. And it was a trio from like 1942.

MR: Was that with Teddy Wilson?

CJ: Close. Nat King Cole.

MR: Yeah.

CJ: Playing the crap out of the piano, like I was just like — you know I grew up with lots of Nat King Cole but it was the more popular Nat King Cole and now I'm like this guy set the bar for everybody off this recording from 1942 or whatever year it was, of a trio — a bass-less trio.

MR: No bass player, wow.

CJ: And it's like where have I been like what did I miss? You know what I mean? In the lineage of the whole thing. So what are they missing now I don't know. I mean I think — some things I think are the same, like the hippest thing going. For me the hippest thing going was Branford Marsalis and Sting and Wynton and a bunch of things. Now they have this thing going it's still Brad Mehldau and I don't know who are the younger cats. I guess the piano player — all these names are going to escape me right now — but there's the swing to — in instrumental jazz anyway — toward whatever the new kid on the — it was Roy Hargrove for the longest time. They're still listening to Roy Hargrove. I'm like that's great but man there's so much history in Roy's playing coming from the masters. So I think that's the great thing about education is that we do get to share some reality checks on the history and the pedagogy of the music in a learning space. And I'm so afraid because I just hope that these learning spaces continue to exist because the world is getting swallowed up by a lot of other things that are much more negative.

MR: Is it an issue for you to try to keep up with contemporary media? You're supposed to be an instructor.

CJ: It's horrible.

MR: It's like what's new THIS week.

CJ: Actually what I really don't like, again I guess I'm getting old because I've lived through a generation of the heyday of making money off records in jazz. Or not even making money but like clearing a profit. Maybe a small profit, but not going the other way. And now with the gobbling up of our, you know the Maria Schneider whole thing that she's gone into with the digital world gobbling us up, I totally agree with her. I mean I'm told to have this app on my phone that's called "Spotify Artist" where I count, and the

industry is counting how many people are listening to my music. And they can really see it.

MR: And what do they do with that information?

CJ: Well they decide whether or not I'll get a gig first of all, or they'll decide whether or not my music is worthy. In their world it has to do with playlists. I mean we never had playlists when I was a kid we made our own playlists. You know? So yeah it's scary times to say the least. And there's no money — I mean there is money out there, I have some students that are quite successful with this new platform, like former students that have gone on to really great careers, but I also have a huge swath of musicians that are not even willing to record at a high level because what's the point? It costs so much. It's this infernal machine.

MR: Have you self-financed some of your recordings over the last ten years or so?

CJ: I'm in the middle of one right now. I have, mostly through grant funding. Although I have to say the last small album I did was the first time in a long time where I went into the studio and the label paid me, they paid my musicians and they paid for all of the production and they still printed CDs. They had grants to do that mind you. But that's also a very big difference between Canada and the U.S.

MR: That it's still happening in Canada?

CJ: Yeah, there's still a lot of media funding that was, you know, that laws were put into place. It's like if you're going to go and destroy us you better have a bit of funding left to prop up the industry that once was, or for us to continue in it otherwise not much is going to happen with art.

MR: Wow. Well I'd like to talk about your extensive range of compositions. Can you describe where — let's suppose I commissioned you for something for Hamilton College, something new.

CJ: Yeah.

MR: What would be the first question you would ask of me for some guidelines.

CJ: I think, whoa that's a big one. I'm certainly not going to dump my world onto yours and go I'm just going to do this. I would want to get to know a little bit about the space you're living in and what is feeding your environment culturally and through the natural and through the urban environment and what is — even historically. Maybe there's some great figure there that I want to put a lens on. Do you know what I mean? I like to put my lens on things. Or, a lens on your — things that are important to you, and try to capture that I suppose through my music. I would also want to know what level of musicians I'm writing for too, although that's basically it. I'd want to have a conversation. I'd want to go for lunch and go, "Tell me about yourself. You're going to commission me? I want to know why this interests you and what is the feeling in the music that you want to have.

It's kind of like a painting. It's like if you commission me for a painting you're going to give me a subject matter, most likely, unless you're like no I don't want that, it's like all about Christine and whatever space she's in she can just write whatever she wants. Or we approach it another way which is like tell me — I want to get to know what elements I'm dealing with from your space.

MR: That's very illuminating I think. Because some people might say well I want to know the instrumentation and what are you going to pay me, really logistical things, but it makes sense with what I've been reading about you. And what if I said, "Okay I want another 'Habitat' from you." Habitat part two.

CJ: Ooh ra. Well that's a big album. And I'm putting a new one out in June that I'm really excited about, which is ironically about the subject we're talking about. And I think, I highlighted in my liner notes that nobody's going to read 'cause they're not going to buy the CD because they're going to just listen to it on Spotify, no offense. But each piece has been a commission. There are seven pieces, six of them are big commissions and one actually is kind of an inner commission from my bandmates to myself, we all commissioned each other, or gave each other topics to pass around. So I don't even have time to get into it on the liner notes because there's not enough space anymore, unless I write a book about it, which I might have to do on the side eventually. But where was I going with this? The commissioning idea? Oh yeah, so this whole album coming up is kind of different from "Habitat" and "Treelines" because those were, for the most part, me hanging out in my space. And I suppose the commissioning came from quite a bit of government funding because I was always running off to a retreat to write or for having some reason to write. Like sometimes I was like I just want to write for my band. I want to write for the musicians that are in my band, I want to write for all sorts of things. This one is like I've written for a bunch of different situations like what you described. You know how much money are you paying me, who's the soloist in the band, what are the highlights, what's the topic? One guy was so cool, he was like, "I loved 'Treelines' so much but you didn't call a song 'Treelines.' Can you write a piece called 'Treelines?'" And I was like that's brilliant, you're right I never did write a piece called "Treelines." So that was on "Habitat." So it was like a little connector. And now this next one is, for the most part, commissions that may or may not have featured my sister or may have featured myself or may have featured other musicians. And then I just kind of re-orchestrated it to match the ensemble I worked with in Montreal going back to "Habitat" and "Treelines."

MR: Interesting you mentioned liner notes because that's where much of my jazz education came from, reading the back of the liner notes. And for "Habitat," speaking of liner notes,

CJ: You found them?

MR: I want to read an excerpt and I'm wondering if you've heard this. It's from a website called Jazz DiGamma, which I believe came from a fellow in Brooklyn. And it's really, really lengthy, I'm going to read a small part of it if I can. It's referring to "Habitat." Christine Jensen's "Habitat." And it says, "Its lines leap off planes to join other lines that leap off other planes, there to reconstitute in harmonic progressions that entwine like the double helix of a musical DNA that is subtle and nimble and barely discernable but in actual fact it is arthoscopically formed by other lines that shape this gorgeous musical icosehedron.

CJ: Wow. Can you send that to me?

MR: Wow. And it goes on and on. This fellow is like a poet and I will send you the link to it. But I think I had a question there, and that is, it's two parts. What do you think about when you hear something like that? And do you think of your own music in such deep and poetic terms?

CJ: I do not. I wish I could. I think that's a reflection off of my art through their art in a way, with the art of word and I wish I could do that but I think my artwork ended up in music. And I mean I think it's the greatest gift back to me is when people really are engaged in anything I do. I'm not making them do it. You know what I mean? I'm not like you have to sit down and listen to me. I'm more like here's my attempt at describing my feelings and my thoughts and my process and I'm putting it out and hopefully I get something back through things like that actually, whether they do a painting or they're on a drive and they hear the music and they're like you made the environment look different or something.

MR: When do your titles come into play?

CJ: My titles. Someone asked — I was on an interview just before this and that same question came up. They were like, "How do you come up with your titles?" And I said well I think again it comes from — I mean again, with commissions there might be something outlined verbally about the piece. For example I just did an album with the Winnipeg Jazz Orchestra with my friend Jill Townsend and we equally wrote the same amount of music and we had a theme. So the themes were pretty easy to get into, the theme was water. That's a pretty broad theme by the way. And then we were like we are both in Canada, we both grew up on water, we both grew up on opposite coasts. She was from Nova Scotia and I was from B.C. And we both wrote about pieces from each side. So I wrote about a piece off the St. Lawrence River, she wrote a piece off of Nova Scotia, and then we both wrote pieces based off of areas around the Pacific Northwest. So those titles were really fun to come up with. And I had a theme. So I was like, oh water, one thing I've always, you know, where's that place I love to go with water. And one that pops into my head was like being in the place I was born which is Sechelt, British

Columbia. It's a beautiful — it's just all view of water and mountains, and hang out with my cousin and learning how to skip rocks. So I was trying to get the idea of rock skipping, getting past three, getting past four, getting past five, and the whole calm kind of feeling of the water lapping on the beach. So I — you know I had a lot to work with there. So it's called "Rock Skipping Under the Half Moon" because we were always out there just before dinner or just after dinner, and then we were being called in and by then it was so dark we couldn't skip rocks anymore. So that's a story. And then I have a story —

MR: I love it. Are you familiar with the American Entertainer Steve Allen?

CJ: Yes. My mother used to listen to him.

MR: Okay. Because I asked him a question about naming instrumental compositions and he could be pithy and a bit sarcastic and he said basically well instrumental music can't tell you anything.

CJ: No.

MR: But you're saying that you write music without lyrics that reflects memories that you have.

CJ: Yeah it does. It reflects those childhood memories of innocence a lot. I think there's a point in our lives where the innocent line happens and it breaks and you're not innocent anymore, and I think a lot like that kind of thing was then. But if I go back to that project, the other piece was completely in the now, which was a piece about me learning how to paddleboard over rapids and I guess there were a lot of currents, so it was just in the now so it was just called "Passing — Passing Machine" is that it? I forget. But something like that. But it was just the area I was in and the moment I'm in. So sometimes I capture just that exact moment I'm in that has nothing to do with my past. Do you know what I mean?

MR: Would you say you had —

CJ: So sometimes I guess I do reflections and sometimes I'm doing — or reflections from childhood and other times I'm doing reflections of something very recent. Or I might be imagining something I've never done so there's no rhyme or reason to titles sometimes. But fantasy is a big part of it for me. I'll send you my new liner notes of my new album because it's all about what we're talking about. And one of the things is that I start my liner notes saying I've always had my nose in a book and — or my family always laughed or my family always noticed or something, I forget what I said, about me always having my nose in a book. And so as much as I had this gorgeous supernatural environment around me just like Ingrid did, and I think it comes through in her trumpet and her writing, I think also I was really, I've always been very interested in American literature actually, or more current American literature like Jonathan Franzen. I love his

descriptions of society in general so I might just sit and — I've written pieces about his books and his place with emotion.

MR: Was there any sibling envy or competition between you and Ingrid?

CJ: I think there always is in families and there probably was with us, probably to do with our parents or with other people and getting attention. I mean that's a lot of what childhood is, getting your parents' attention. And getting her attention. I was the younger sister, I wanted her attention you know. And I got it, in the best of ways I think. But yeah I mean it's — there may have been moments of that, especially when you're younger, but it's now grown into like wow, I wish I had your problems. I wish you had my problems kind of thing. Like we were both struggling all the time about the element of time and the element of creating music and raising families. So we don't have time for jealousy so much I don't think. Different things happened to both of us though.

MR: Okay here's a quote from you. It started out you were talking about being an instrumentalist, a saxophonist and an educator. But you focused on composing and you said the essence of being a composer is the deepest, hardest place I go in my life. And can you tell me why it's hard? Why is it — I mean from speaking —

CJ: Oh, I think it's hard because I have to start fresh all the time. It's like a new start every time I compose, as opposed to performance where I'm kind of revisiting a rhythm, a rhythmic activity in a way, and not that composing isn't but I'm in the now with other people as opposed to composition where I'm having to get into the now with myself. And I think there's a really big difference from the act of the two things. There's similarities but there's also this, I mean I went through so much isolation the last four years with this. So it's led me to a place where I'm like, I just want to, I really want to find a balance between performance and composition. Because both of them are good for my soul.

MR: Do you write at the computer?

CJ: No. I wish. I can barely turn my computer on when I'm composing. Once I get into it I will, and that means writing larger ensemble music. I can write all small sketches on a notepad. That's what I do. Yeah.

MR: Okay. I remember going to the house of your colleague Dave Rivello and I was pleased to see this big — it was almost like an architectural type table and he had his King manuscript paper.

CJ: He's very good at outlining with all that. I wish I was as organized. Although I mean every artist has their space, I think there's been lots of documentaries on that. But your living/sort of working space and it's certainly — I actually thought oh I'm finally going to be a real professor with my own office at a school and I'm going to work there. And I can barely work there because there's too much work there. I still need my own space to work in. So your home space becomes really important I think once you figure that out.

And Dave's done a great job of that with having lots of space to freely write. And that's kind of what I have with my studio in Montreal that I'm still spending a lot of time at, and hopefully I'll develop one here more but I haven't yet because I'm still trying to figure out Rochester.

MR: Have you ever had an experience — you wrote glowingly about people that you work with, the soloists and so forth. I wonder if you've ever had a semi-awkward experience where people were interpreting your music during their solos in a fashion that didn't really ring for you, and as the composer have you had to say, "Could you consider a different approach to this?"

CJ: Yeah that happens all the time I think. I might, you know, if I write something new and I throw it down in front of the band, this is a large ensemble. It's a little different than small ensemble. If I'm in a quartet I can freely go crazy with my thoughts with the band because there's only three or four of them in the room with me. But when you get to the hierarchy of placing a big band together there's like little leadership roles going on everywhere. Right? So lead trumpet players are different everywhere. Drummers are different everywhere. So I might have to get into things more with certain players depending on the situation. With my own band if I'm writing something new and it's not really connecting I might just stop and talk about what I wrote about and why I wrote it, and that tends to put the whole thing back together. So for example "Nishiyuu" on "Habitat" came — I wrote that because I had been probably sitting in my office doing work or writing, and every day on the CBC the news came on about this certain tribe up north beyond Hudson Bay up on the east side of Hudson Bay — do you know how far away that is? That's very, very, very far away. It's like 3000 kilometers or something. And they're sitting up there, this tribe of — a young group of people from the community, and they're like we have no drinking water and we need to send a message to the government about how our drinking water is not clean. We live in Canada. Every person should have the right to clean drinking water. And they went on this march. So I hadn't told anyone this, they didn't know what Nishiyuu was. I'm like you know this is actually a branch off the Cree tribe that is going to march through the most miserable conditions in the world of weather from north to south from January to March to Parliament Hill so they meet at the right time with the Prime Minister and blah blah. So anyway I have to tell this story and I was practically in tears over it, and then they played it so beautifully. You know what I mean? But they didn't know what Nishiyuu was, they didn't know anything until I sat down, and I think I pulled a *Globe and Mail* article on it and I gave it to my soloist. I said, "You know what? Just read this and it'll all make sense. You're my leader on this piece." And ever since I just love playing that.

MR: Wow. I watched a video from Jazz Composers Present that you were on, and you were talking about I think the name of the song was "Leap" maybe part three.

CJ: Oh yeah.

MR: You remember that?

CJ: Yeah. That's part of my suite "Under the Influence."

MR: Okay. So you had the score up and you were talking about some of the background, and you mentioned a couple of things like this came from — I'm not sure if it was you said Ionian but you said melodic— what is it?

CJ: Yeah the modes.

MR: The modes. And then you said you were doing something with a Coltrane matrix. So I think my question here is have you ever written anything, or have your students written anything that has no seemingly recognizable form or technique or chord structure but it sounds good and you don't know why?

CJ: I'm not sure about my students. I find — that's a really tough question. I mean form is something, it's kind of the philosophy of what is composition. A philosophy in composition is describing form and manipulating form and creating form. Sometimes, it's like everything else, it's all been done. You know what I mean? Everything's been done, we're going to just start repeating over and over what's been done and maybe something we can add on to it. Much like twelve tone ruined classical music. Are we going to do that again with jazz form I guess, which comes off a bunch of other forms anyway. But I'm kind of going off. It's a tough question.

MR: I think what I'm after here is I have to admit I used to have an attitude about not just composers but pop musicians who didn't have any theoretical background. And thankfully I got over it. Because I recognized that some of these musicians come up with things that I don't think they would have done had they had a bunch of rules or ways to do things that they learned from somebody else. And so I'm just wondering if —

CJ: Definitely a more natural process of coming from a different place that is not chock full of harmony rules, but also more basic too because it's not like they're studying the classical art form of their instrument. That's the best way I can put it. They're just working on their sound and putting out. And to me that's intriguing because I think it's a place I go to. I was brought up on a lot of pop music. It was kind of my drug as a kid was to listen to top 40 radio and find things I liked. And I didn't like everything. I really didn't like everything but there was the odd thing I really liked.

MR: What did you like?

CJ: Oh I loved The Police. When that album came out I was just like "Synchronicity" — so I know they had other albums before and I liked those ones too but once "Synchronicity" hit I was like how did they do this album? Why is it the way it is? And that has been a

huge influence on me. I can hear it in a lot of progressions I write actually. And then I'm trying to push past those progressions sometimes. And it's all — just to put the word out — it's all Ionian. They don't leave Ionian.

MR: Did you sit at the piano with records and poke out the bass parts and then work out the chords to some of these songs?

CJ: Yeah. For pop songs definitely. I also read sheet music because my mother was a classical piano teacher and she didn't understand the aural concept at all. And it wasn't her fault and I actually feel for her because I think she really, in another life she wanted to be a jazz musician. Do you know what I mean? She was just on a quest all the time. There was music that made her feel good. Well you know when it makes you feel good I guess is the sort of driving underneath it all for me. What makes me go wow, I just want to listen to that again and figure it out. And unfortunately I'm a very — I have very close friends that are musicians, it's mostly men, that are really great buddies of mine and I'll sit there and they'll go, "Isn't this amazing?" And I'm like, "No I'm just not hearing what you're hearing." And mostly it's because I was never into vocals. I was never into the poetry of the word. I was too transfixed with the melodies and the harmonies and the rhythms that the vocal part just got completely sidelined. And now I'm really into it so it's okay. It just took me a long time. You know? But I think that if you meet all these great instrumental musicians, they kind of — again our lens has been trained a certain way. I think classical piano does it to you too, or classical lessons of some sort, that train you into really hearing the — visualizing the rhythm and the harmony much more so, so it distracts, but not in a bad way. It fed me lots of ideas. But The Police, I can't sing every lyric but they did catch me a lot on the lyric to the point where I was doing that repetitive thing that kids do when they just listen to something over and over and they can't stop listening. And how can you do that with jazz you know, like that's kind of cool.

MR: Yeah The Police were on my top five band list as well.

CJ: Yeah. I studied with Vince Mendoza slightly and he rings true when he goes, "Now there's music you listened to but there's also music that found you," or "you didn't find it, it found you" and then he played this amazing list of music that covers a very broad spectrum of classical, jazz and pop. And it's really — it made me think and go you know that is what is the building blocks for you as a musician, whether you're a composer or a player there's these building blocks that land on us and we have to just find the right space for them to go and then move on to all this other stuff.

MR: One time I wrote a big band chart and I don't know why this happened, it might have been because Dave Rivello shared a quote about waiting as long as you can before you put in a solo section.

CJ: Yeah.

MR: I think it came from Bob Brookmeyer, but I said, okay I'm going to try to write a chart with no solos. And it made me realize that we depend on solos sometimes simply to have a chart that's more than three minutes long.

CJ: It's true. Your development has to go a different way, which is probably why it was a good thing for me to study a lot of classical theory when I was at McGill. I had to do two years of classical and it really taught me — I mean I played through it, I was playing through Beethoven sonatas, I was working on Mozart binary form, all this stuff and I think Beethoven sonatas were what probably helped me understand that form has to keep going and it's not just variations. I mean you can add other things. So that's kind of what Beethoven to me — at least that was my stepping stone to realizing I can transition and it just goes back, it all goes back again to Vince Mendoza, the idea of transition and transitioning maybe to a different key center than you thought you would land in, like Mahler or someone, where the twists and turns grab your ear but they go somewhere else and it doesn't have to come from the soloist. So yeah, I think I've gotten past three minutes on a few things, although no, I still put solos in sometimes but they're kind of more like transitions than solos.

MR: Yeah. Less about —

CJ: In a way I want to blow up that whole Brookmeyer thing and just go music is music. I know that he liked to push us through development and it's important, but what is the purpose of the development? Do you know what I mean? I mean I'd like to see three soloists going at it for ten seconds and then move on, and I'm not sure that's a solo section anymore. Do you know what I mean? It might just be part of the form that leads to the real solo section. So again going back to McNeely it's about putting — making the stage, first of all you've got to have a stage, and you start introducing characters. And the characters can be the form. The characters can be the soloist. The characters can be sections of — are what we call choirs in the big band, so I have my choir of saxophones, I have a choir of trombones, I have a choir of trumpets. And this is a language I'm starting to use with my students a lot more, because I think we always have this very formal way of saying Trumpet One, Two, Three, Four or Trombone — you know, Trombones and Bass Trombone. It's like no, it's just a choir. It's like a soprano and alto, a tenor and a trombone. Maybe the trombones is not so much soprano but there's a lead and they stack down. So if we think of choirs. The rhythm section is a different choir. It's more of a percussive choir with the piano really stating a lot of melody but the bass is all about rhythm to me.

MR: The bass is supreme.

CJ: Na, the drums are supreme but they also don't work without the bass so yeah.

MR: Yeah, well.

CJ: I know.

MR: If you're in the middle of composing or arranging, do you become obsessed with it? And by that I mean you're driving to Eastman or you're taking a walk that you find that you're working on this arrangement like all right what do I do next. It's like trying to solve little problems in your head?

CJ: Yeah it's the construction that goes on and you're, again this interview I did before had a similar question and I was just like — he asked me, he said, "So do you ever dream about your compositions? Like do you have dreams about compositions or that you want to have?" And I was like you mean literally sleeping? I'm like when I sleep I sleep. Unfortunately I get caught up in something that I might be working in, that's a drag because I can't sleep because of that. But it's not a drag because that means I'm really activated in solving — doing that problem solving you're talking about. Because something has to come from the step I've stopped at. Or, it also might go in the garbage, who knows? But it's sort of like I really get into it I do feel the power of the composition moving forward. And that comes also from preparation a little bit. So a lot of times I might try for, I mean another word I'm always using is a lot of my music is not programmatic necessarily but it's full of different episodes, so it's episodic. It's quite a bit of episodic — I mean I can break some stuff down into a one minute lead sheet if I had to, but instead I've been adding episodes all around it. So those are little — I like to think of it as working on a puzzle. It's really a puzzle for me.

MR: Do you find that your music —

CJ: Well I have this little red piece and I don't know where it goes yet but I'm going to have to build up around it to get that little red piece connecting. But then there another red piece spot too, I'm not sure which one I'll get to — it kind of has to drive me as much as I drive it, which is different than problem solving necessarily.

MR: Wow. Very interesting. Does your music, especially for large ensembles, really need to have a conductor?

CJ: Not always, no. And I'm noticing that too with a lot of that, the Brookmeyer stuff, I'm really caught up in like oh I can see what happens. He started to get really into the composer side of things, not sitting in the band, and then all of a sudden the Vanguard band, how are they going to run this episodic piece, that — someone has to direct it. Same with McNeely — has to direct it from the piano. And there's just little cues. And so that might be something that you kind of keep in your tool kit as one of the actions happening in the piece because you want to play on it or you don't want to be conducting. The other action that happens to me with my students is that they get so good at the music I don't need to stand there anymore. Right? If they're well rehearsed and the piece goes by I barely need to be there. However, if I am going to be there I'm hoping to give them

some energy. Like Ray Wright — I don't know, or sorry, Ray Ricker — Ray Wright's dead. Ray Ricker was at a concert, or he watched a concert the other night and he wrote me a note and he said, "I love your minimalistic conducting. It's not like you're like the wind symphony conductors where you have to direct everything." And I said, "You don't need to direct everything in jazz." I mean it depends on context a lot but if the rhythm keeps the pulse of what's going on, and it's well rehearsed, you barely have to do anything. All you can do is throw good energy at it, at a certain point, which is what the great conductors were able to do because they had such great orchestras that knew the repertoire as far as I'm concerned. You know.

MR: Yeah. Basie at the piano just like —

CJ: Yeah. He was barely doing anything he was just like one-two-three-four off you go. And yeah, I think the jazz repertoire for large ensemble is evolving all the time rhythmically and you know using different meters and things. So it gets complicated. It's all time and place and what are we going to do. But I have to say when I took my band on tour, the one opportunity I got to go across Canada, by day three I did not need to stand in front of that band so I just started picking up my horn and playing melodies with them, or taking some solos, but it wasn't about me soloing it was about just making the music — having fun with the music in the moment, which I hope happened.

MR: Is there any Phil Woods in your alto playing that you're aware of?

CJ: People tell me I have Phil Woods in my playing and that was one of those records that I got when I was young. And I think I obsessed a little bit over Billy Joel for a while so —

MR: I was listening to —

CJ: I met him once so I didn't really get to spend enough time with Phil Woods and I should have.

MR: Oh. I was listening to one of your tunes called "Infinitude" and I think that's where I — it wasn't obvious, something about it just made me think that you had listened to him to some extent.

CJ: Yeah I listened to him and I played his solos and I thought he was such an extension of Charlie Parker as he was, that it was comforting in a way that someone contemporary could play like that.

MR: Yeah. You and your sister play well together and I think it was on that particular tune I noticed what a wonderful sound that she has down low on her —

CJ: Yeah, she's really good at low. Better than any trumpet player I've ever heard. And she — you know that's again, going back to collecting your tools, I think that's one she's used to her advantage. And she used to play flugelhorn but now she has a trumpet that she's able to mask that flugelhorn sound and get low and warm and in tune and it sounds nearly like it's an extension of the horn. But I know how she got there actually so if any

kid ever wants to know I'll tell them, sit down an hour a day and do long tones at the bottom.

MR: When we started today you had made a reference to jazz education and how — I forget your exact words but it leads me to wonder about women in jazz and women in jazz education. Do you have a feeling about — is it progressing? Where is it at?

CJ: I have very mixed feelings about the word "progressing" with it. But there are some great things that are coming out. There've always been some great things. Maybe this time they won't be so hidden. I still think there's a boy's club going on and an example of a hero of mine, honestly, I've been really obsessing over those Rick Beato videos lately. They're all men talking about music for the most part. There are some women, very few, and then they like to do things like say "Brad Mehldau is the pianist of our — the greatest pianist of our generation." And I'm like you're not helping anything when you say these things. Do you know what I mean? I mean it's great Brad is endowed as the greatest piano player of our generation. A whole bunch of people are going to watch that and go "Brad Mehldau is the greatest piano player of our generation." And I'm like there are so many other pianists that you're not talking about in this breath that you might want to defend. I'm not going to get into it right now, but how do we change this machine of men kind of being the ones on stage still with other men. What does it take to change it? I don't know. Does it mean the club owners have to say you need to have 50/50 on stage of 25/75 I don't know, that would be even a cool number. And all of a sudden is that going to change the audience? Is it going to change something else? Is it going to make it less popular? What's going on here? It's not even popular anyway. Programming is everything to me.

MR: I remember speaking with Karolina Strassmayer and when she was chosen for this European big band it was like splashed all over whatever media would pick up on it, and then it became a tag line — you know it's like a tag line with her.

CJ: Tokenism.

MR: The one female musician and isn't that wonderful?

CJ: Yes. I've worked over there too. I was the one female musician too. So, and I'm guilty of it myself. I'm surrounding myself with mostly men in a big band but at least I have my music, I have control over some of the situation. I have my music, I get to choose who's there, including my sister. I get to play in it this way. I get to play whatever I want. And I've kind of created my own circumstances for this to happen and I can't say that it's a bad thing because the other thing was like going, "Oh I just really want to play in that big band down the road that I can play second alto in." It just didn't really ring true to me either. It wasn't part of the visual or the visage of this music. It's more like I want to be creating and not just interpreting I guess. So lucky me because I just sort of threw all that

other stuff aside and went if you want me it's about what I have to offer as a composer and a musician I guess. I mean sometimes I get — don't get me wrong, I love to be able to sit down and play through a set of great — someone else's music that's really fun like give me Jim McNeely's book any day or the Vanguard book. I would just love to be a part of that. But my path just kind of wove in a different direction because — probably because of just privilege and opportunity and those two lacking things at times also.

MR: It's been a fascinating conversation. I'm going to wrap up with — it's not really a musical question but I'm curious, growing up to the north, in Canada, and then coming here, do you have an opinion or a sense of where the United States is currently?

CJ: That's a terribly long horrible question. I'm very worried. At the same time I think some things will always survive. It's kind of like watching Wall-E the movie and you see the little plant that survives through all of it. I feel like music is like that. It's always going to be there. It's always going to survive. And I hope that it gives good to people. Because there's so much other stuff out there that's not good, like crime. I moved here and I just went, "Oh yeah, guns?" Guns and Medicare. These are the two issues. And in fact guns are the top of the issue because they stem from all of the strife underneath it that is happening because of the erosion of simple things like — like in Canada you don't spend your day talking about Medicare and going broke. You know what I mean? You don't — that is just not a part of the conversation. Okay we've gotten rid of something that takes up a lot of time and money and now we can focus on other things. Not that Canada is the perfect place because it certainly isn't. There's a whole bunch of underlying things with social medical systems right now especially. The economy is still a problem. Here I think there's a different focus on racial divide. Canada has a lot of issues they've never worked on. They just didn't have to deal with it the way the United States — they would have if they had more migration up there. And there is some, but it's not at the level of what happened in the States with the red line and with economic disparity amongst race. It's just so wrong. So I'm here dealing with all this as a institution of privilege really, but hope that I do think that the positive thing is that we're all at least facing the demons I'm talking about and trying to find other solutions. It's going to be hard. It's going to take a lot of like really breaking some tradition that has been in the hands of the privileged. I don't know what it is and I don't know how it will happen because the government coming in — just like in Canada — it's going to slash anything to do with the arts because the arts are a voice for political movement.

MR: You've given us a lot to think about.

CJ: I hope I said that okay but I'm just like —

MR: You said it's a long and terrible question. It's terrible that we have to even ask it, but I appreciate your thoughts today, and — very illuminating.

CJ: Yeah. And I think the whole world, again, I wrote a piece for Ryan Truesdell, he did a string project and it's called "Tilting World." And I really feel like the world did somewhere tilt in the pandemic because that's — it just shook everything up and now we have to deal with things.

MR: Well I want to wish you best of luck in your continued composing and playing and educating and all of that, and I really appreciate your time today.

CJ: Thank you. You inspire me by asking questions. Sometimes I'm like I don't know what I'm doing.

MR: Sounds to me like you know what you're doing.

CJ: Sometimes. Yeah.

MR: All right. I hope to cross paths with you sometime.

CJ: Yes. Look me up if you're in the neighborhood.

MR: Very good.

CJ: Nice to meet you, Monk.

MR: Likewise.

CJ: Thanks so much.

MR: Okay.